to five months. He, nevertheless, emphasised the need for a swift response, ‘if possible within the next day’. According to Dobrynin, Kennedy stated:

> there is very little time to resolve this whole issue. Unfortunately, events are developing too quickly. The request for a reply tomorrow is just that – a request and not an ultimatum. The president hopes that the head of the Soviet government will understand him correctly.[68]

Dobrynin assured Moscow that, ‘it went without saying that the Soviet government would not accept any ultimatums and it was good that the American government recognised this’. What is the most effective way of delivering an ultimatum? It is to state that it is not an ultimatum. What is the most effective way of dealing with an ultimatum? It is to state that it is not an ultimatum. When delivering an ultimatum, it may also help to suggest the threat is out of the hands of the person making the threat. According to Dobrynin, ‘R. Kennedy mentioned as if in passing that there are many unreasonable heads among the generals, and not only among the generals who are itching for a fight.’ Khrushchev was worried about warmongers in the Pentagon. Whatever RFK’s motives for raising the issue, it would not have lowered Khrushchev’s anxiety levels. Were these concerns legitimate? There is no evidence at all of any acts (or plots) of insubordination by senior military officers. The President remained their commander-in-chief.

Nevertheless, President Eisenhower had delegated authority to military commanders of unified and specified commands (notably SAC), that in specific circumstances they had the authority to use nuclear weapons. As Daniel Ellsberg shows, President Kennedy chose to continue with these arrangements. For the commander-in-chief of SAC that could mean choosing whether (or how) to implement the SIOP. As the two F-102 fighters sent to support Major Maultsby’s U2 showed, United States command and control arrangements meant even individual pilots could use a nuclear weapon within their rules of engagement. And for the most part those rules were maintained only by procedural arrangements (as well the training and discipline of the military personnel involved). Electronic